



Investigation report

Rejected take-off and runway overrun, Tarlton Springs - Executive brief

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INVESTIGATION WORKFLOW SUITE

Contents

What happened	3
Why it happened.....	4
What we found.....	5
Contributing safety factors	5
Other factors that increased risk	5
Other findings.....	5
What is being done	7
Distribution	7
Figures	8

What happened

On 18 June 2026, Saltbush Air flight SB512 was preparing to depart runway 09 at Tarlton Springs Aerodrome. The aircraft was a 50-seat twin-turboprop registered VH-SBQ. On board were 44 passengers, 2 flight crew and 1 cabin crew. The doors closed at 07:16 UTC, 40 minutes behind schedule, and the departure took place in the hour after last light. The aerodrome's only runway inspection that day had been carried out before the first scheduled arrival. It recorded the movement area as clear.

The tower cleared the aircraft for take-off at 07:29:10, with the wind from 090 at 6 kt. The tower did not offer a further runway inspection, and the crew did not request one. The first officer was flying. The take-off roll began at 07:30:02, with both engines set at almost identical power. At 07:30:29 the crew called V1 at 112 kt. Two seconds later the first officer saw two kangaroos crossing the runway from the northern side to the south, at an estimated range of around 200 m.

The take-off was rejected at 07:30:32 with the words "Stopping. I have control." At that moment the aircraft was travelling at 118 kt, which was 6 kt and 3 seconds past V1. It had 695 m of sealed runway remaining. The power levers reached flight idle within 0.6 seconds. One second later the No. 2 propeller and the right main landing gear struck both animals. Three No. 2 propeller blades were damaged beyond limits, and No. 2 reverse thrust was unavailable for the rest of the stop.

The response on the flight deck was prompt. Maximum braking was established 2 seconds after the decision, against a fleet average of 3.2 seconds, and No. 1 reverse thrust was selected at 07:30:36. Even so, the aircraft slowed less than the scheduled performance figures predicted. It left the end of the sealed runway at approximately 21 kt and ran onto the graded gravel of the runway end safety area, where its deceleration fell further. The aircraft came to rest at 07:30:57, 62 m into the 90 m safety area and 28 m short of its end. It was upright and on the extended centreline, and there was no fire.

At the pilot in command's request, the tower activated the aerodrome emergency plan at 07:32:10. No evacuation was commanded. Instead, the passengers left by the forward airstair in a precautionary disembarkation that began at 07:34:40, and all were clear by 07:38:48. Nobody was seriously injured, although one cabin crew member reported bruising during the disembarkation. The aircraft was substantially damaged, and both right main tyres deflated. Two kangaroos were killed, and the aerodrome was closed for 4 hours 20 minutes.

Why it happened

The occurrence began with two kangaroos entering the runway strip and moving onto the sealed surface. The investigation found it extremely likely that their presence influenced the occurrence. It led to two further events: the decision to reject the take-off 6 kt above V1, and the strike on the No. 2 propeller and right main landing gear.

It was extremely likely that rejecting the take-off above V1 contributed to the shortfall in deceleration. It was virtually certain that the strike also contributed. The strike damaged the No. 2 propeller, and No. 2 reverse thrust was then unavailable for the stop. Taken together, these left the aircraft slowing less than its scheduled accelerate-stop performance predicted. It was virtually certain that this shortfall in deceleration carried the aircraft past the end of the sealed runway and into the runway end safety area.

The rejection above V1 was shaped by the crew's training. Saltbush Air's rejected take-off training covered aircraft system failures below V1 only. It was likely that this influenced the decision to reject at 118 kt. This is a safety issue.

The animals were on the runway because of when the aircraft departed and the condition of the aerodrome's boundary. The departure took place in the hour after last light, which is the peak period of kangaroo movement. It was likely that this timing contributed. Repair of the perimeter fence had been deferred for three budget cycles, and it was very likely that this allowed the animals to reach the runway strip. This is a safety issue. Behind the deferral sat the regulatory framework. A documented wildlife plan was required only at aerodromes above a size threshold, and Tarlton Springs did not meet it. It was likely that this contributed to the fence deferral. This is a safety issue.

Nobody checked the runway before the aircraft lined up. No runway inspection was requested before this first departure after last light, and it was likely that this contributed to the animals being on the runway undetected. The arrangements for inspections explain why none was requested. A runway inspection was required only at listed aerodromes, and an aerodrome qualified for the list only after a strike had occurred. It was very likely that this criterion contributed to the absence of an inspection. This is a safety issue. It was likely that the absence of a documented wildlife plan also contributed to these inspection arrangements. The evening service itself had been approved as a schedule change, so the route risk assessment was not reopened. It was likely that this contributed to the inspection arrangements staying as they were. This is a safety issue.

The crew's response limited the outcome. Maximum braking and No. 1 reverse thrust were applied without delay, and it was very likely that this influenced where the aircraft came to rest, inside the runway end safety area.

One further matter could not be settled. The investigation examined whether the intensity of the runway edge lighting reduced the crew's ability to detect the animals, but it reached no finding either way. The lighting intensity was measured, but only seven days after the occurrence. Nothing showed how the lights were operating on the night, and the two accounts of the lighting disagreed. No study was found that links an edge light reading of 131% to the detection of an object on the runway surface. Resolving the matter would need evidence of the lighting on the night and of how that lighting affects detection.

What we found

A finding stated without a likelihood term was established as fact.

Contributing safety factors

- It was virtually certain that a documented wildlife plan was required only above a size threshold that the aerodrome did not meet, and it was likely that this contributed to the occurrence. (Safety issue)
- The perimeter fence repair had been deferred for three budget cycles, which was virtually certain, and this very likely contributed to the occurrence. (Safety issue)
- It was very likely that the departure took place in the hour after last light, the peak of kangaroo movement, and likely that this timing contributed to the occurrence.
- With virtual certainty, the evening service was approved as a schedule change and the route risk assessment was not reopened, and it was likely that this contributed to the occurrence. (Safety issue)
- A runway inspection was required only at listed aerodromes, and the listing criterion was a strike at that aerodrome. Both points were virtually certain, and this arrangement very likely contributed to the occurrence. (Safety issue)
- It was virtually certain that no runway inspection was requested before the first departure after last light, and it was likely that this contributed to the occurrence.
- Two kangaroos entered the runway strip and moved onto the sealed surface, which was virtually certain, and their presence very likely contributed to the occurrence.
- It was very likely that rejected take-off training covered aircraft system failures below V1 only, and likely that this contributed to the occurrence. (Safety issue)
- With virtual certainty, the take-off was rejected 6 kt above V1, and this very likely contributed to the occurrence.
- The No. 2 propeller and the right main gear struck two kangaroos, and this strike contributed to the occurrence.
- Deceleration was achieved below the scheduled accelerate-stop performance, and this shortfall contributed to the occurrence.

Other factors that increased risk

- It was virtually certain that the cabin floor proximity emergency lighting was partially unserviceable. It was very likely that this increased risk, although it did not influence this occurrence. (Safety issue)
- The crew were operating the fifth sector, 11 hours into duty and 40 minutes behind schedule, which was virtually certain. It was likely that this increased risk, although the recorded data did not support any influence on this occurrence.

Other findings

- A take-off commenced with a tailwind above limits was examined and ruled out as very unlikely, because the aerodrome observations and the recorded aircraft data both showed a headwind throughout the roll.
- The investigation also examined a No. 2 engine power loss during the take-off roll and ruled it out as very unlikely, because both engines were at matched take-off power until the reject and the No. 2 damage began at the moment of impact.

- Maximum braking and No. 1 reverse were applied without delay, and it was very likely that this reduced risk by bringing the aircraft to rest inside the runway end safety area.

What is being done

Aerodrome Standard AS-139 required a documented wildlife hazard management plan only above a size threshold, and Tarlton Springs did not meet it. No action has been recorded against this issue. [NOT ESTABLISHED: any response by the body responsible for AS-139]

The aerodrome's own works register recorded the northern perimeter fence as failed in 2023. Its repair was then deferred at three budget rounds. The investigation walked and photographed the failed section on 23 June 2026. Even so, no repair, funding decision or other response by the aerodrome operator has been recorded. [NOT ESTABLISHED: the aerodrome operator's response to the fence deferral]

The evening service had been approved as a schedule change, so the route risk assessment for Tarlton Springs was not reopened. On 19 June 2026 the Head of Flying Operations suspended the evening Tarlton Springs service. No review has been recorded, however, either of the route risk assessment or of the change process that approved the service. [NOT ESTABLISHED: whether the service will resume, and on what assessment]

Under the operator's procedures, an aerodrome could be listed for a pre-departure runway inspection only after a reported strike there. No provision asked crews to report sightings. The investigation raised this with the operator's Safety Department on 2 July 2026. The investigator considers that the issue warrants a recommendation in its own right. [NOT ESTABLISHED: the Safety Department's response]

Rejected take-off training covered aircraft system failures below V1 only. No crew had been given an obstruction on the runway as a training scenario. No action has been recorded against this issue. [NOT ESTABLISHED: any proposed change to the training syllabus or to the operations manual]

The cabin floor proximity emergency lighting was partially unserviceable because of a failed ballast, and the daily test could not detect this. The same ballast is fitted across the aircraft type, so the fleet-wide question is with engineering. This issue remains open until that answer is received. [NOT ESTABLISHED: the outcome of the fleet check, and any change to the 24-month test interval]

Distribution

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Figures



Figure 1: The northern perimeter fence at the 1,050 m mark, photographed on the site visit: the fallen section and the animal pad through it. Site inspection photograph SV-2026-0417-07, northern boundary at the 1,050 m runway marker, taken 23/06/2026